

TSA's new 'Gold+' program looks to increase private security screening at airports

transportation security administration officers staff a checkpoint at o'hare international airport in chicago ill in this 2010 file photo the agency was created after the sept 11 2001 attacks but not every u s airport uses federal screeners scott olson getty imageshide caption washington federal officers handle security screening at all but a small fraction of u s airports but the trump administration is hoping to change that under the transportation security administration's new program called tsa gold private companies would play a much larger role in airport security than they have in decades the tsa is set to host officials from airports and security contractors to an industry day at its springfield va headquarterston thursday as it looks to develop tsa gold a public private program that the agency calls transformative the agency is billing the program as an update to the screening partnership program or spp in which 20 u s airports currently use private security screeners rather than federal workers tsa gold marks a significant evolution in the agency's approach to aviation security a tsa spokesperson told npr via an emailed statement the agency says airports that opt into the program would be able to tailor security systems for their facility and avoid the tsa staffing shortages that became a very public headache at airports during the recent government shutdown over homeland security funding it also says the program would bring the latest technology such as ai tools to airport screening operations to increase capacity and cut wait times although the agency did not specify how those gains would be achieved from the details shared so far the equipment would be the contractors' responsibility a departure from the current spp system in which tsa controls the equipment and oversees the security contract the tsa says it would perform the oversight role it currently does industry partners can manage equipment and introduce innovations while travelers enjoy a smooth predictable and bespoke experience the tsa said as it unveiled tsa gold airports currently using the private screening partnership program range from san francisco and kansas city to sarasota fla and atlantic city n j along with smaller facilities in montana wyoming and other states calls for privatizing airport security screening have come from president trump and republicans in congress echoing a recommendation in the conservatives project 2025 handbook for a second trump term but there are also signs of bipartisan interest in some level of private control over airport security as seen in atlanta where city leaders recently voted to explore joining the screening partnership program rep andrew garbarino r n y chair of the house committee on homeland security touted that bipartisan interest on wednesday during a hearing on tsa modernization but everett kelley president of the american federation of government employees union which represents tsa officers said he opposes further privatization including the tsa gold program warning that it would hamper accountability and transparency under the new program kelley said contract workers would earn less than tsa officers he added that while many transportation security officers hold security clearances under the new plan the government would be ceding direct operational control of the most sensitive technology in the aviation security enterprise to private vendors the white house budget released last month promises to save some 52 million by privatizing airport screeners and requiring small airports to enroll in the spp but officials at the hearing urged lawmakers to preserve airports' ability to choose chris mclaughlin ceo of dallas fort worth international airport noted that the spp has been in place since aviation security underwent drastic changes following the sept 11 2001 terrorist attacks which led to the creation of the tsa and the spp system we've had federalized screening for 25 years almost mclaughlin said large airports like san francisco have had an spp program for 25 years both airports arrangements work well for them he told garbarino the system has been safe for 25 years he said it's important that airports have options the new gold program echoes the trump administration's promise to bring a golden age of travel to the american public department of transportation secretary sean duffy touted those plans earlier this week as he unveiled 970 million in funding to improve passengers' experiences at airports from adding family friendly security screening lanes to improving restrooms and children's play areas the money for those projects comes from the infrastructure investment and jobs act a biden era law aiming to update airports' aging infrastructure

<https://www.npr.org/2026/05/21/g-s1-123215/tsa-gold-private-security-screening-airports>

Even as anxieties grow under Trump these swing voters aren't ready to back Democrats

President Trump boards Air Force One after speaking to reporters on Wednesday. Chip Somodevilla/Getty Images. **Swing voters in North Carolina say they are frustrated with President Trump and the state of the economy but aren't ready to abandon him or his party as the midterms inch closer.** NPR observed two online focus groups on Tuesday featuring 12 voters in North Carolina who voted for Joe Biden in 2020 and then Trump in 2024. These focus groups were conducted by messaging and market research firms Engagious and Sagoas as part of the Swing Voter Project. Seven of the voters who participated identified as independents, four said they were Republicans and one identified as a Democrat. That's a more Republican-leaning cohort than prior months' focus groups. Half of these voters said they overall disapprove of the job Trump is doing, and a lot of that frustration has to do with the fact they do not think Trump is attuned to the growing economic pain that many Americans are feeling as the war in Iran continues. Eight of 12 voters said Trump is out of touch with their economic concerns, and nine said they are more economically anxious now than they were before Trump took office last year. These numbers are not statistically significant because this isn't a scientific poll, but focus groups do provide some insight into what is showing up in polling. I don't think he really understands the American people, what we are going through, what we're suffering with, said April M., referencing high gas prices. All participants agreed to be part of the focus groups on condition that they be identified by their first names and last initials. Only some voters were particularly upset when they were shown this recent comment Trump made to reporters: "The only thing that matters when I'm talking about Iran, they can't have a nuclear weapon." He said, "I don't think about Americans' financial situation. I don't think about anybody. I think about one thing: we cannot let Iran have a nuclear weapon. I'm glad he's concerned about the nuclear weapon." Leslie B. said, "But what about people needing to put food on the table and get to their jobs?" But the other half of these swing voters remain pretty aligned with Trump. Rich Thau, president of Engagious and the moderator of the groups, said many of these voters are happy that Trump has delivered on some of his promises, like securing the border. They're focusing on the larger picture of what he's done on immigration as opposed to the specific incidents that got him in a lot of hot water, he said. And secondly, despite everything that they're unhappy with, and there's certainly a lot they complained about, they still see him as a strong leader. When asked if they see Trump as strong or weak, nine of the 12 said strong, none said weak. If he says he's going to do something, he does it, period. Vikki B. said, "Whether you like it or not, he does it. That's why I feel like he's a strong president." Thau said he thinks this portrayal of strength, even when it is chaotic, is why many of these voters are sticking around. The image he portrays is such an important part of their support for him, he said. That to me is a really important observation: that it's not just about the policies and whether he succeeds or not; it's how he comes across as a leader, and he never ever ever tries to display weakness, despite the frustration with the economy. No voters in these groups said they were going to specifically vote for Democrats in the upcoming election in an effort to respond to Trump. Barrette G. who said he disapproves of the job Trump is doing, said he thinks a protest is a wasted vote. He wasn't thinking of strategically backing Democrats; you have to look at the individual candidate and what do you think they're going to do, he said. What are they bringing to the table? Whose interest do you feel like they're going to represent? He said he doesn't think Democrats are going to represent his interest by combatting Trump. Right now, I feel like the Democrats as a party, I feel like they've strayed from the roots of America, he said. I think they're serving the fringes too much, but then again, I think a lot of it is theatrics. At the end of the day, I don't think either party is serving the middle class anymore. Several voters had a negative perception of the Democratic party because they view it as fractured. I think they need to come together, said April M. I think everybody is going their own way; they don't know what to do. They are so upset with what the Republicans are doing, they don't think to come together themselves to be stronger so they can outdo what the Republicans are doing. Added Vivian T., I believe they need to show a united front for all the splits over political support. The focus groups were aligned over artificial intelligence while voters see some benefits to AI, most have some fears about the effects the technology will have on jobs and humanity. Writ Large's Steve M. said his big fears are the displacement of large sectors of jobs as well as the effect AI is having on students. It's teaching an entire generation that they don't need to have original thoughts, think critically, he said, because AI is going to do it for you. Steve said he'd ideally like to see the technology shut down, but that is unlikely.

to happen instead he said he d like to see global leaders work together to regulate the technology which many of the voters agreed with what that says to me is they don t see another way forward thau said thau told npr that while many of these voters have concerns there is also a sense of a lack of agency he said there is a sense among them that there s not much that they can do about it themselves so they are hoping political leaders intervene they think this is the only way that we ll get anything meaningful done on ai thau said and they re concerned about it profoundly concerned

<https://www.npr.org/2026/05/21/nx-s1-5828924/north-carolina-swing-voter-focus-group>

As floods get worse Britain tries a new solution: beavers

may 18 24 as the federal government halts plans to address climate change states cities regions and even neighborhoods are trying to fill the gap by cutting climate pollution and adapting to extreme weather npr is dedicating a week to stories and conversations about how communities are moving forward on climate solutions despite significant political headwinds this beaver was released on oct 11 2023 in greenford england as part of the ealing beaver project a family of five beavers two adults and three kits was released into the 20 acre paradise fields nature reserve in west london becoming the first beavers in the west of the british capital in 400 years dan kitwood getty imageshide caption npr is dedicating a week to stories and conversations about how local communities are moving forward on climate solutions london until two years ago west london s greenford tube station used to flood whenever it rained heavily the train tracks are aboveground but the ticket office would often get inundated sandbags still line the corridor but in october 2023 a new family moved in nearby determined to halt the water the family members built their house from scratch with local wood and kept odd hours sleeping all day and working only at dawn and dusk they even put their young children to work a beaver swims in a pond after being released on oct 11 2023 in greenford england as part of the ealing beaver project the beavers that were released are part of an unlikely effort to bring back a vanished species and help britain adapt to a very modern problem climate change dan kitwood getty imageshide caption west london s greenford tube station used to flood whenever it rained heavily the train tracks are aboveground but the ticket office would often get inundated now a nearby pond and wetland created by reintroduced beavers has helped mitigate flooding in the area sarah tilotta for nprhide caption the beavers are part of an unlikely effort to bring back a vanished species and help britain adapt to a very modern problem climate change britain is famous for drizzle but climate change is making rainfall heavier and more erratic places that didn t used to flood are now waterlogged so scientists have enlisted some of the animal kingdom s best flood engineers beavers to help in west london conservationists got a government license to resettle a family of five beavers in a 20 acre urban park near the greenford tube station it used to be a golf course with a creek running through it within weeks the beavers dammed up the creek creating a pond that holds water and stops it from spilling into the city they also diverted the creek s flow into smaller tributaries creating a wetland that better absorbs heavy rainfall mitigating the risk of flooding downstream they effectively turned this site into a giant sponge that can take heavy rainfall and slowly release water back into the landscape creating a lot more resilience for flooding explains sean mccormack a local veterinarian who started the ealing beaver project named for the london borough of ealing where it s located scenes from the paradise fields nature reserve in greenford west london where a family of five beavers has transformed what used to be a golf course into an urban wetland that helps absorb heavy rainfall and prevent local flooding sarah tilotta for nprhide caption sean mccormack a local veterinarian started the ealing beaver project with elliot newton a rewilding expert with the conservation group citizen zoo sarah tilotta for nprhide caption not only has the local tube station stopped flooding but the beavers have also coaxed back other species by felling trees they ve also opened up the canopy and we ve seen an abundance of biodiversity mccormack says freshwater shrimp have appeared in the creek he says plus eight new species of birds two types of bats and rare brown hairstreak butterflies which lay their eggs on blackthorn branches nibbled by beavers the beavers have also allowed the city to scrap expensive plans to dig a reservoir and levee we said the beavers can do it for a fraction of the cost certainly more sustainably mccormack says a tour participant photographs the tiny white eggs of the rare brown hairstreak butterfly research indicates that the hairstreak may benefit from beavers nibbling on blackthorn which encourages the new growth on which the butterflies prefer to lay their eggs sarah tilotta for nprhide caption commuters tourists and recreationists enjoy hiking paths and sometimes stop to watch the beavers in action inside the paradise fields nature reserve sarah tilotta for nprhide caption now joggers and teenagers stop to gawk at the beavers in action there are guided walks and beaver safaris on a recent spring evening a reddish brown adult scampered in and out of the water chomping on a felled willow tree eurasian beavers can weigh up to 65 pounds this one was the size of a fat golden retriever the ealing beaver project is one of dozens of sites across britain where land managers are using beavers to restore wetlands and tame flooding but first they had to bring them back from extinction in britain humans hunted beavers to extinction more than 400 years ago by the early 20th century only about 1 200 native beavers were left in europe and northern asia surviving in parts of norway france germany belarus ukraine russia mongolia and

china sweden reintroduced them in the 1920s and other countries followed part of a broader effort to restore native species by studying fossils scientists determined that today's norwegian beavers are genetically most similar to the beavers that lived in britain centuries ago so in 2009 wildlife officials relocated two norwegian beavers to knapdale forest a temperate rainforest in western scotland that pair named millie and bjornar became the adam and eve of the modern day british beaver population the scottish forestry department calls them the original beaver power couple we became kind of attached to millie and bjornar says pete creech a forest ranger who remembers when they arrived scrambling out of crates and splashing into a loch he recalls their enthusiasm lots of squeaking participants of a guided tour look at a dam built by beavers in a nature reserve in greenford beavers build dams in part to raise water levels and hide underwater from predators sarah tilotta for npr hide caption oliver hughes and his father michael hughes who traveled from north wales to celebrate oliver's birthday keep their binoculars trained on the marshland hoping to spot the resident beavers living at the ealing beaver project sarah tilotta for npr hide caption creech set up hidden cameras to capture their crepuscular dawn and dusk movements within weeks the beavers dammed up a tiny river creating an enormous lagoon where swans now nest while the united kingdom overall is getting wetter some areas including parts of scotland are getting drier even seeing a growing threat of wildfires beavers ensure this rainforest stays wet and thus abundant that's especially important at a time when wetlands are disappearing with many drained for development wetlands are one of the most biodiverse habitats in the world creech notes the u k has lost over 95 of its wetlands and now we're frantically trying to put them back not everyone thinks rodents are the best way to do that though a coot paddles through the marshland at the ealing beaver project sarah tilotta for npr hide caption unlike in london where they're enclosed in urban parks beavers in scotland went forth and multiplied spreading onto private land their numbers have been boosted by beaver bombers renegade wildlife enthusiasts who've released unlicensed beavers into areas where they might not be welcome as the beaver population has expanded we've seen more farmers getting concerned says kate maitland a regional representative for scotland's national farmers union beavers can dam up irrigation channels flooding crops it's quite devastating to see acres and acres of your land sitting underwater maitland says tom bowser left with binoculars is a fifth generation scottish farmer who runs beaver watching tours like this one in june 2024 on his farm near doune perthshire scotland beavers were reintroduced in scotland in 2009 after having been hunted to extinction andy buchanan afp via getty images hide caption they can also fell centuries old trees and collapse riverbanks exacerbating erosion maitland a farmer's daughter says she once got the full length of her leg stuck in a beaver burrow while walking along the banks of a stream on her family's land the scottish government has set up a fund to rebuild riverbanks and other beaver damage if repairs are in the public interest that doesn't typically cover damage to private land some farmers shoot beavers though they need a license to do so since beavers are a protected species it's also illegal to disassemble beaver dams or lodges that are more than two weeks old instead farmers are encouraged to call wildlife officials who trap and relocate beavers that's where london's beavers came from other farmers have learned to like the new neighbors and even celebrate them a beaver swims in a pond created by a beaver dam on bowser's farm on june 16 2024 beavers were hunted to extinction across britain more than 400 years ago and were reintroduced in 2009 some farmers oppose the reintroduction beavers can dam irrigation channels collapse riverbanks and flood crops andy buchanan afp via getty images hide caption tom bowser is a fifth generation farmer in central scotland he has empathy for his fellow farmers when you're trying to grow food the presence of a fat semiaquatic rodent who wants to raise water levels is understandably going to be unpopular bowser's farm is strewn with trees felled by beavers many of the tree trunks have been whittled into hourglass shapes by beavers sharp teeth some of them teeter about to fall bowser wraps young trees in chicken wire if he wants to protect them in london officials painted trunks with sand which gets stuck in beavers teeth but he has found that the benefits outweigh the costs a beaver dam has diverted floodwaters from his driveway creating a pond lined with benches that's frequented by tourists he runs spring and summer beaver watching tours that are especially popular with children who previously knew beavers only from fairy tales we get people from all around the world coming here now bowser says growing up here you didn't see any car you didn't recognize hunter cannon 10 from harefield london takes a guided tour of the ealing beaver project tourists and residents alike enjoy wildlife in the paradise fields nature reserve as part of the ealing beaver project a family of five beavers was introduced into the park in 2023 damming up a creek reducing flooding and boosting biodiversity sarah tilotta for npr hide caption the

beaver buzz is catching the animals have made comebacks in italy portugal and the ukrainian part of the danube river delta in the united states then how beaver project releases them into fire damaged areas of washington state in idaho nasa is helping track beavers work in britain beavers are especially popular with land managers who are short staffed want more stories like this sign up for npr sup first newsletter south norwood country park is a 125 acre nature reserve with only one employee volunteers do some of the ground maintenance they even don waders to dredge streams once a year that's exactly the sort of work the beavers would do naturally says countryside warden ian glover he has applied for a license and hopes to welcome beavers in 2028 or 2029 like ealing south norwood is on london's urban periphery it's famous for birds with boxes for kestrels to nest in perched atop poplars the park's peak bird count 177 species goes back to 1935 but birds have been in decline across europe glover hopes beavers might help reverse that locally by damming up streams and creating wetlands that attract more birds beavers build dams and raise water levels in part to hide from predators glover notes but most of their predators including wolves and bears have been extinct in britain for centuries obviously they haven't gotten the memo glover laughs and these beavers have been so useful nobody's telling them participants join a guided tour of a new beaver habitat in the paradise fields nature reserve the new reserve acts like a 20 acre sponge in the center of the british capital helping to absorb heavy rainfall climate change is making rainfall more intense and erratic across britain sarah tilotta for npr hide caption

<https://www.npr.org/2026/05/21/nx-s1-5738979/beavers-britain-climate-change-flooding>

COVID is shaping Americans' reaction to Ebola and hantavirus

a medical professional from children's national hospital works at a coronavirus drive through testing site on april 2 2020 in washington d c the covid 19 pandemic is shaping how many americans are reacting to ebola and hantavirus drew angerer getty imageshide caption global health emergencies are back in the headlines with recent outbreaks of hantavirus on a cruise ship and ebola in the democratic republic of congo the internet has responded accordingly with the situation evoking painful reminders of covid 19 for many people questions filled with fear have surfaced on reddit comedic videos are all over tiktok and instagram and search terms involving the word pandemic have increased on google trends in recent weeks the covid 19 pandemic introduced people across the u s to a global health emergency that they may have never imagined that experience is coloring how some people are thinking about ebola and hantavirus public health and infectious disease experts say fear around exotic sounding diseases has always existed but now people know how a pandemic can change their life as chandra harvey a content creator on instagram whose joking video about another possible pandemic received over 100 000 views told npr we're all dealing with ptsd from covid for harvey covid 19 heavily impacted her family with a few relatives hospitalized covid scarred all of us she said early in the covid 19 pandemic you were worried about your friends and neighbors and loved ones dying from covid said dr ali s khan dean of the college of public health at the university of nebraska medical center more than 1 million americans died of covid 19 despite ebola currently spreading in parts of eastern africa infectious disease experts told npr that the average american should not be concerned about ebola or hantavirus becoming a repeat of covid 19 here's what to know about how ebola and hantavirus differ from covid 19 as well as what people should keep in mind when reading alarming headlines or scrolling through social media there is the dread factor with certain diseases said dr amesh adalja a senior scholar at the johns hopkins center for health security and an infectious disease physician even though far more people die from influenza on average every year than from ebola certain diseases spark dread in people he said harvey the content creator said hearing about two diseases back to back jumped out to her family ebola with the combination of hantavirus at the same time it's just like it's too much she said any time you hear of anything from a virus perspective it's just scary adalja said the memory of covid 19 also causes americans to lump outbreaks together but the diseases spread differently covid 19 like measles can spread through the air ebola is typically spread through bodily fluids such as vomit or blood hantavirus most often spreads to humans through contact with urine feces or saliva from infected rodents though one strain has been identified that can spread from person to person the nuances of the biology of different pathogens the trajectories of different outbreaks that all gets lost because what many people are worried about is having a disruptive event like covid upend their entire life adalja said some may also be alarmed about how deadly these diseases are and the lack of treatment options as well as the coincidence that they both gained attention in the same month also the delay in detecting the ebola outbreak has made it harder to control the situation infectious disease specialists told npr dr craig spencer an associate professor of public health at brown university and an emergency medicine physician with brown's pandemic center told npr's a martínez that the trump administration's firing of staff at the centers for disease control and prevention the cutting of the u s agency for international development and the u s withdrawal from the world health organization are having an impact on the current response in the democratic republic of congo in a statement to npr on monday the state department said it was false to claim that the usaid reform has negatively impacted our ability to respond to ebola adding that funding and support to combat ebola would continue caitlin rivers an epidemiologist at johns hopkins said she's very concerned about the ebola outbreak as an epidemiologist however i'm not worried as a mom meaning i'm not expecting ebola to influence my community or really the united states said rivers who wrote the book crisis averted the hidden science of fighting outbreaks similarly public health officials say the risk to the general public from hantavirus is very low pandemics and epidemics have been a part of american and global life for centuries going back to ancient times in the 20th century flu pandemics dominated the years of 1918 1957 and 1968 in this century there have been notable outbreaks of sars severe acute respiratory syndrome the h1n1 flu virus swine flu the zika virus mpox and measles ebola has also had multiple outbreaks in the past few decades with the one in 2014 killing more than 11 000 people humans have been fighting infectious diseases since they first evolved adalja said adalja said he puts the ebola and hantavirus outbreaks into the larger history of pandemics epidemics and outbreaks not everything has the ability to be this disruptive

force the way covid was people have to understand that pandemics have always been something that humans are going to face adalja said but science and technology and medicine they offer us the ability to master these issues to make them less impactful to be proactive rivers the epidemiologist said that in her experience a major outbreak of international attention happens about every two years they re a lot more frequent than i think many people appreciate instead of immediately turning to dread experts said americans can focus on targeted questions and stay informed with information from local state and national health officials adalja said to ask are people talking about this spreading the same way covid does similarly dr abraar karan an infectious disease physician and faculty member at stanford university thinks about personal risk are experts talking about my individual risk like me leaving my house and going to work and coming home adalja also said to be very wary of what you see on social media if it s not coming from an official press source because there is a lot of disinformation being deliberately spread harvey the instagram influencer said that since covid 19 she calls herself the hand washing police she carries hand sanitizer in her purse and constantly makes her son wash his hands a lot of those things became routines for us rivers said if people are worried they can wear a mask and avoid crowded indoor spaces or if available vaccinate focusing on those controllables can be helpful she said

<https://www.npr.org/2026/05/21/nx-s1-5825891/hantavirus-ebola-covid-pandemic-virus>

A guide to converting your lawn into a wildlife friendly garden

three years ago this garden near the kansas city metro area was a lawn now it's full of midwest native plants like the ohio spiderwort and mountain mint pictured here that attract plenty of pollinators celia llopis jepsen kcurhide caption npr is dedicating a week to stories and conversations about how communities are moving forward on climate solutions despite significant political headwinds as the federal government halts plans to address climate change states cities regions and even neighborhoods are trying to fill the gap by cutting climate pollution and adapting to extreme weather lawns are great surfaces for throwing a football or laying out a picnic but turfgrass in the united states now covers an estimated 40 million acres an area about the size of the state of georgia and these manicured lawns take an environmental toll gas powered yard equipment like lawn mowers and trimmers put out 30 million tons of air pollutants a year the environmental protection agency says to keep our lawns tidy and green we also use weedkillers and fertilizers when it rains those chemicals escape our yards and make their way through storm drains to our lakes and rivers shrinking lawns can reduce all these impacts it can also create space for gardens that feed wildlife great news at a time when north america has lost one quarter of its birds and the u.s. has lost one fifth of its butterflies university of delaware entomologist doug tallamy has calculated that if americans reduced their lawns by half and added native plant gardens to feed birds butterflies and other wildlife this would create more habitat than yellowstone and a dozen other major national parks combined interested in ditching your lawn these tips can get you started consider starting small especially if you're new to gardening it can be overwhelming to take on an expansive garden says stacia stek executive director of deep roots kc a group that teaches the public how and why to plant habitat gardens in the kansas city region as you get more comfortable there's always room to expand replacing the whole lawn at once can lead to weed mud and erosion problems so it requires careful planning and more work a good place to remove some grass could be along a fence or sidewalk if you have a tree in your yard consider putting a flower bed around it this is called a soft landing because it gives caterpillars a safe place to go after they finish feeding on your tree's leaves there they can make their chrysalises and cocoons among flowers and leaf litter safe from lawnmowers and emerge as adult butterflies and moths bees fireflies and other insects will find homes there too using flowers trees and shrubs that have existed in north america for millennia is a surefire way to turn your space into a wildlife magnet that's because many insects feed on specific native plants a famous example is the monarch caterpillar's need for milkweed it can't eat anything else native plants also boost insect populations which feed birds frogs lizards and other animals to pick your specific plants first note whether your new flower bed will be in shade or sun and what the ground is like for example is the soil very sandy is the area usually wet next find a native plant group specific to your region because native plants for arizona and new york are completely different many of these groups have online cheat sheets for picking plants midwesterners for example can check out outgrownative.org which has sample flower bed plans and top 10 lists of plants for different light and soil conditions also know what style you're looking for are you looking for short ground covers do you dream of a cottage core garden with big drifts of pastel flowers do you want a hedge between you and your neighbors finally know your local rules some homeowners associations or city codes restrict tall flowers and grasses in the front yard for example one way to kill your grass is to solarize it according to deep roots kc a group that teaches the public how and why to plant habitat gardens in the kansas city region using transparent plastic to kill existing vegetation during the height of summer is a low labor approach to remove lawn cydney rosashide caption there are plenty of ways to kill your grass you can kill it by covering it with cardboard to deprive it of sunlight you can lay down sheets of clear plastic to block light and rain while baking the grass in the sun's heat you can rent a sod cutter or use a shovel to dig the turf out by hand you can also use herbicide iowa state university has a nice guide to carrying out these options there's no right way to kill your grass the best option for you will likely depend on your particular outdoor space how much hands on time you want to spend removing the grass and how long you're willing to wait for it to die smothering the grass with cardboard can take weeks or months for example if you're using plastic or cardboard there's no need to remove the grass once it's completely dead unless you see seedheads or grass pieces that could resprout the dead turf will decompose on its own and add organic matter to your garden you can also use cardboard to smother your grass but it may take weeks or months to die igor paszkiewicz getty images hide caption the tricky thing about native plants is that typical garden centers often don't stock many of

them many opt to focus on popular ornamentals such as peonies and boxwoods that originally came from other continents native plant or wildlife advocacy groups often post indexes online of native plant nurseries or pop up events where native plants will be sold but buying lots of plants can be expensive jeffrey popp director of restoration at anne arundel watershed stewards academy near annapolis md has a few tips to save money when buying plants first look for places that sell plugs small young plants in six packs or flats you can buy native plant plugs relatively inexpensive popp says despite being small those plugs can grow fast also some homeowners with native plant gardens will give away seedlings for free or swap plants he says try searching facebook for local groups dedicated to native plants this might mean a native plant society for example or a local chapter of wild ones a group that encourages wildlife friendly gardening you can also start plants from seed but this takes patience nurseries like prairie moon a major native plant seller based in minnesota have detailed instructions for how to get each kind of seed to germinate native plants laid out and ready to be planted deep roots hide caption get them in the ground and put mulch around them there's no need to add extra garden soil during planting if you've picked native plants suited to your soil conditions advice on how far to space the plants out varies depending on the plant but basically you'll want to space them so that once the plants mature your flower bed is full plants want to touch each other says paula diaz a master gardener in kansas city they don't want acres of mulch in between them this is better for you too because eventually you won't have to replenish mulch or pull weeds as often it'll take a few years to get to that point though gardeners like to say that many perennials sleep creep leap meaning they won't seem to do much in their first year will only grow a little in their second and then will thrive in their third although it's true that some species can grow faster as young plants grow you'll especially have to keep an eye out for weeds and to make sure that empty spaces between plants are mulched you may also need to water them while they develop strong root systems if you've chosen plants appropriate to your area you shouldn't have to water them once they mature except perhaps during serious dry spells in the winter don't cut the plants all the way to the ground leave at least part of the stems because native bees nest in them also leave fallen leaves because butterflies and other critters are overwintering in there enjoy diaz has gardened with native plants for more than a decade and five of her neighbors have followed suit there's always a bird that's singing or frogs that are croaking she says being able to go outside and just walk around and see life that happened because you planted what you planted it helps your heart celia llopis jepsen is host of the environmental podcast up from dust and a reporter for harvest public media the podcast episode was produced by sylvie douglas this story was edited by shahla farzan malaka gharib and neela banerjee the visual editor is cjr iculan we'd love to hear from you email us at lifekit@npr.org listen to life kit on apple podcasts and spotify or sign up for our newsletter

<https://www.npr.org/2026/05/21/nx-s1-5821165/a-guide-to-converting-your-lawn-into-a-wildlife-friendly-garden>

Spencer Pratt is 'winning the internet ' but can he become mayor of Los Angeles?

spencer pratt speaks during an appearance on fox friends at fox news headquarters on wednesday jan 28 2026 in new york photo by andy kropo invision ap andy kropo ap invisionhide caption to spencer pratt and his supporters becoming mayor of los angeles first means winning the internet pratt has amplified outlandish artificial intelligence videos including one depicting lightsaber duels between him and the city's current mayor karen bass and another where he's portrayed as batman descending on a burning los angeles to save the day his campaign has tapped an army of freelance clippers to edit short social media snippets of him bashing the city's leaders and he talks about nonexistent super meth plaguing the city's streets and pushed false narratives about california lawmakers response to the palisades fire a screenshot of an artificial intelligence video created by a supporter of spencer pratt charlie curran via twitterhide caption it's perhaps no surprise that the 42 year old former villain of the reality television show the hills knows how to work the attention economy but he's doing so by borrowing the combative and mocking style of politics popular in fringe online forums and celebrated by allies of president trump he's probably the most trumpian candidate we've ever seen in terms of house style said steve bannon trump's former top adviser trump's superpower was bringing in people into politics who hate politics and that's what he's doing online right now pratt's internet antics are up against long odds on june 2 angeles will go to the polls for the city's jungle primary a nonpartisan contest where pratt a republican will face off against democratic incumbent bass and progressive council member nithya raman if any candidate surpasses 50 of the vote that person becomes mayor if nobody does the top two vote getters compete in a november runoff polls show pratt and raman neck and neck with bass commanding a comfortable lead yet pratt is harnessing the web to shake things up he has leapt into the usually more mundane world of municipal politics with brash and extreme rhetoric taking to tiktok with direct to camera videos condemning bass response to the devastating pacific palisades wildfires that claimed his family's home he describes bass as the mayor who let the town burn down pratt has also blamed city leaders with enabling the deterioration of city residents quality of life or as he puts it on tiktok a city battered by fires homelessness and crime a framing that would sound familiar to anyone watching right wing influencers and streamers pratt says without evidence that socialists in la city government are stealing your money he denigrates the city's homeless as fentanyl addled zombies and he has promised to clear out encampments by mass arresting people living on the streets he's accused bass and raman of running a grift with the homeless industrial complex a vague and unsubstantiated claim aimed at whipping up his fans online according to dan cassino a professor of government at fairleigh dickinson university who studies masculinity and politics these are the sorts of things that play very well in red pill forums where there's this idea that everyone is in control of their lives and we need to embrace hard truths out there that they won't teach you in school he said pratt's endorsement from podcaster joe rogan cassino said is proof of pratt's credibility in the manosphere the bro friendly world of male influencers who wage war against polite society focusing on this audience is a way to target young men cassino said just as trump did in 2024 and now we see spencer pratt doing the same thing former los angeles city councilman mike bonin has been watching pratt's campaign morph from unserious long shot to top three contender pratt had a megaphone of millions of social media followers before he ran for public office that has helped supercharge the spread of the ai slop videos his fans have made so has elon musk's repeated re sharing and replies to pratt's content on x the platform the tech mogul owns to his 240 million followers when pratt wants his incendiary campaign messages and ai content to spread even farther conservative influencers like laura loomer ben shapiro and benny johnson are at the ready commenting and reposting to juice pratt's reach winning the internet is not the same thing as winning the election but it can help said bonin who now directs the pat brown institute for public affairs at cal state los angeles spencer pratt often turns to tiktok to promote his candidacy for mayor of los angeles tiktokhide caption he points to how the kinetic digital campaign of new york city mayor zohran mamdani inundated instagram reels and tiktok with videos showing how natural and conversant he was with the format more close to home los angeles controller kenneth meija won his 2022 election using his two corgi son billboards and in social media videos as a way of appealing to those terminally online the difference with pratt bonin said is that he's using the leverage of the well oiled right wing online media machine unlike left leaning candidates right leaning candidates come

into an internet ecosystem that is well practiced in promoting itself through its various networks he said also giving a signal boost bonin said was the launch of california post a west coast edition of conservativenew york postowned by rupert murdoch around the same time pratt launched his campaign the outlet has been reinforcing the supposed dystopian crisis los angeles has been living through and that is a big part of pratt's narrative bonin said pratt and his campaign did not return requests for an interview bass did not offer any comment raman through a spokesman dismissed pratt's online tactics saying the ai slop videos show how out of touch he is with something that's an existential concern to the city's entertainment industry hollywood jobs are being devastated by ai meanwhile spencer pratt is using his platform to promote ai generated content amplifying the very technology replacing the workers he claims to care about raman said in a statement our videos are made by working film and television professionals who believe los angeles can be better there are two ways to respond to this try to meet pratt on his level or don't participate at all cassino the government professor at fairleigh dickinson university said raman and bass are taking the rose garden strategy by not trying to match the intensity and absurdity of pratt's online campaign which he said is probably politically wise he's more chronically online than they are he has fans who generate this stuff for him in a way that they don't so any attempt for them to do this will make them look inauthentic he said it is difficult to gauge how much of pratt's content and rage baiting is coming across the social media feeds of los angeles voters but at least on x he's been praised as the candidate who is the most anti woke and based internet slang for being unapologetically one's self and unafraid of offending others his favorite pejorative for bass is karen basura which is spanish for trash and he calls the mayor's supporters bassholes cruel bully like language that cassino said is catering to young men online if people are voting for spencer pratt because they think it's funny versus because they seriously want him to be mayor the vote still counts cassino said however it is resonating or not with voters pratt is not slowing his inflammatory language and pugnacious tone it's a posture being lapped up by the online maga sphere it also represents the new template for right wing political candidates both national and local bannon added pratt knows it's not politics it's drama said bannon who was a hollywood financier before he got into politics he's got a warrior mentality if bannon found any criticism of pratt's campaign it would be pratt's shameless promotion of ai slop a fierce critic of silicon valley bannon said the videos are entertaining but they risk turning off voters who can see them as trivializing the race not to mention how the internet is already glutted with ai junk and fakes on the ai slop he's one inch away from jumping the shark bannon said it can be effective but it's starting to get tiresome and it could backfire if you promote it too much internet notoriety though cannot dislodge one fact about los angeles registered democrats outnumber republicans three to one presenting pratt with a serious challenge if he advances to the november runoff trump on wednesday signaled support for pratt unsurprisingly the mayoral hopeful did not immediately blast this out to his social media followers that's because while pratt is a registered republican he has tried to separate himself from the maga movement and has repeatedly highlighted how the mayor's race in los angeles is nonpartisan it's a tightrope walk that bannon one of the chief architects of the maga movement is keenly attuned to as he offers conditional praise for pratt tell him i would endorse him bannon said but i don't want to hurt his chances of winning in la

<https://www.npr.org/2026/05/21/nx-s1-5827724/spencer-pratt-los-angeles-mayor-ai-slop-manosphere>

The Education Department is hiring — while it's being dismantled

President Donald Trump's plans to close the U.S. Department of Education have run headlong into an awkward reality: the agency does important work that still needs doing after losing roughly half its staff last year's big reduction in force. The department's student loan office is in a hiring boom: the office of federal student aid (fsa) is adding around 380 new workers according to internal documents obtained by NPR. FSA is the central nervous system of the nation's \$1.7 trillion student loan portfolio; it manages everything from communications with the nation's 43 million borrowers to repayment plans to the free application for federal student aid (fafsa). In April, FSA held an internal all-staff meeting in which employees were told that FSA has 731 full-time equivalent staff, roughly half the staff it had prior to the current Trump administration (1,440) and that it needs to hire an additional 334 FTEs to meet our target, that's according to the documents NPR obtained which were prepared for this meeting. The documents also show FSA has already hired 52 new workers since September. What these job postings confirm is what we've known all along: our jobs matter. Says Rachel Gittleman, a former FSA staffer who is now president of AFGE Local 252, which represents department employees, and our jobs are needed in order for our federal student loan system to function adequately for borrowers. When asked to explain the hiring in light of last year's mass firings, Ellen Keast, the department's press secretary for higher education, responded: returning education to the states and breaking up the federal education bureaucracy does not mean that critical programs won't continue. News of the hiring at FSA was first reported by Politico. Keast says none of these new FSA hires are former employees returning to their old jobs. Still, Gittleman says the jobs themselves haven't changed much. All of the jobs that we have seen postings for since September of last year can be traced to a job that was terminated or, in a certain few scenarios, a job that was subject to a deferred resignation or retirement program. Gittleman says it's unclear what the cost will be to recruit, hire, and train these new employees. FSA certainly has a lot to juggle: rolling out new limits on student loans plus two new repayment plans that's on top of important work that's fallen by the wayside. An investigation from the nonpartisan U.S. Government Accountability Office (GAO) found that right before last year's cuts, FSA stopped reviewing the accuracy of loan servicers' records and recordings of borrower calls. In a public appearance last year, Education Secretary Linda McMahon acknowledged that in some areas, the overall reduction in force at her agency had gone too far. You always just want to cut fat. Sometimes you cut into the muscle, and you cut a little too deep, and we've brought some people back. Not a lot, but we did find that we cut a little bit deep. The office for civil rights (OCR) is another example. There, deep cuts were made, stalled by the courts, and eventually reversed. OCR struggled to process civil rights complaints that unnecessary back and forth at OCR, according to a separate GAO investigation, ended up costing taxpayers between \$28.5 million and \$38 million. This hiring spree at the Education Department comes as McMahon has trumpeted 10 new interagency agreements intended to offload the department's work to other federal agencies, including moving FSA responsibilities to the Treasury Department. In a March letter explaining the need for the Education Department to partner with Treasury, McMahon wrote: for too long, Americans have shouldered the consequences of poor leadership and persistent mismanagement of our federal student aid portfolio. Today, its actions reclaim integrity and accountability for you, the American people. But this hiring suggests it will still be Education Department employees doing the work of the Education Department. In her statement to NPR, Keast said as much: that the agreement with Treasury is for FSA to continue managing and improving delivery of these programs. This confusion over who's doing what came up in a recent Senate hearing when McMahon told lawmakers that in the case of an agreement with the Labor Department, it is the same people from the Department of Education that are at the Department of Labor. It's dealing with the same people that you've known at the Department of Education that are located somewhere else. McMahon's comments befuddled Sen. Tammy Baldwin, a Wisconsin Democrat. You are sending Department of Education employees to work at other agencies to administer the same programs from different buildings, Baldwin said. Incredulous, NPR spoke with another former FSA staffer who was laid off last year. They did not want to be identified because they are in the process of applying for one of these new jobs that they say closely resembles the job they were doing until last year's broad reduction in force. We just want our jobs. We took an oath to serve the public, and that's what we want to do. The former FSA staffer noted one difference with the application process: this time, there is a new series of questions about an applicant's commitment to the Constitution, improving government efficiency, and one question that has already triggered a lawsuit: how would you help advance the president's executive orders and

policy priorities in this role i feel as though they want you to show loyalty to this administration the former staffer says edited by nirvi shahvisual design and development by la johnson

<https://www.npr.org/2026/05/21/nx-s1-5820922/education-department-firings-now-hiring>

Prediction markets are making a 150-year comeback

prediction market sites allow users to put money on everything from the war in iran to the winner of the super bowl but where did these markets come from and what can that history tell us about where they might be going today on the show how betting on popes and presidents long ago planted a seed for a terrorism market in the early 2000s and how those early prediction markets shaped the industry that has taken hold today guests koleman strumpf economics professor at wake forest university paul rhode economic historian at the university of michigan robin hanson associate professor of economics at george mason university and systems architect for the policy analysis market robert forsythe professor of finance at wayne state university and co founder of the iowa political stock market to access bonus episodes and listen to throughline sponsor free subscribe to throughline via apple podcasts or at plus npr org throughline

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Officers who defended Capitol from rioters sue to block payouts from fund

file trump supporters try to break through a police barrier jan 6 2021 at the capitol in washington john minchillo aphide caption washington two police officers who helped defend the u s capitol from an attack by a mob of president donald trump s supporters sued on wednesday to block anyone including jan 6 2021 rioters from receiving payouts from a new 1 776 billion settlement fund for people who claim to be victims of politically motivated prosecutions the officers attorneys filed the federal lawsuit a day after acting attorney general todd blanche defended the fund s creation during a congressional hearing blanche a personal attorney for trump before joining the justice department wouldn t rule out the possibility that rioters who assaulted police on jan 6 would be eligible for fund payouts the lawsuit claims the government s anti weaponization fund is an illegal slush fund that trump will use to finance the insurrectionists and paramilitary groups that commit violence in his name it describes the fund s creation as the most brazen act of presidential corruption this century and calls for dissolving it no statute authorizes its creation the settlement on which it is premised is a corrupt sham and its design violates the constitution and federal law the suit says the fund stems from a settlement of trump s 10 billion lawsuit against the irs over the leak of his tax returns it s designed to compensate those who believe they were mistreated by prior administrations justice department decisions on payouts will be made by a five member commission appointed by the attorney general more than 100 police officers were injured during the capitol riot nearly 1 600 people were charged with jan 6 related crimes but trump used his pardon powers to erase all of those cases in a sweeping act of clemency last year the plaintiffs suing trump over the fund are metropolitan police department officer daniel hodges and former u s capitol police officer harry dunn who is running in maryland for a seat in congress hodges and dunn both testified before congress about their harrowing experiences on jan 6 videos captured a rioter ripping a mask off hodges as he was pinned against a door during a fight for control of a tunnel entrance the officers claim the fund encourages those who enacted violence in the president s name to continue to do so dunn and hodges already face credible threats of death and violence on regular basis the fund substantially increases the danger the suit alleges a commission whose members will be chosen by blanche but have not yet been announced will be charged with deciding who gets paid and how much blanche said in a cnn interview on wednesday that the board will have to consider the person s actions among other factors when deciding whether to give them money but the attorney general added whether the commissioners will give that person money that claimant it s up to them blanche said it s abhorrent to harm law enforcement but added that people that hurt police get money all the time from suing the government he dismissed backlash to the fund as fake outrage blanche and treasury secretary scott bessent also are named as defendants in the officers lawsuit spokespeople for the justice and treasury departments didn t immediately respond to requests for comment on the suit one of the attorneys for the officers is brendan ballou a former justice department prosecutor who handled jan 6 cases

<https://www.npr.org/2026/05/21/g-s1-123293/officers-who-defended-capitol-sue>

Ex-prosecutor charged with sending to herself report on Trump classified probe

the u s department of justice logo is before a news conference monday may 4 2026 in washington julia demaree nikhinson aphide caption washington a former federal prosecutor in florida sent to her personal email account a special counsel report from the investigation into president donald trump s hoarding of classified documents despite a judge s order that it was to remain sealed according to an indictment made public on wednesday carmen lineberger who worked in the u s attorney s office for the southern district of florida and managed its fort pierce branch faces charges including theft of government property and concealment of government records she pleaded not guilty during a court appearance in west palm beach her attorney did not immediately return messages seeking comment prosecutors allege that while serving as a justice department prosecutor last december lineberger sent a copy of the report that special counsel jack smith and his team had prepared recapping their investigation into trump s retention of top secret documents at his mar a lago estate in palm beach to her personal email account at the time she did so the indictment says a judicial order barred justice department employees from sharing transmitting or distributing copies of the report the indictment alleges that lineberger sought to conceal her actions by altering the original file name of the report to bundt_cake_recipe pdf before saving the re titled file on her government computer and emailing it to her personal email account with the subject line of bundt_cake_recipe pdf several months earlier according to the indictment lineberger created on her government computer a document consisting of portions of internal justice department messages along with portions of an internal memorandum with header and footer markings that indicated it was for official use only she sent the material to her personal email address via an attached file titled chocolate_cake_recipe pdf prosecutors say the indictment does not explain why lineberger may have wanted to send the report which prosecutors say she had access to in her professional capacity as a prosecutor to her own email account the volume detailing smith s findings in a criminal investigation once seen as posing significant legal peril to trump has never been seen by the public u s district judge aileen cannon sided with trump s lawyers who argued that releasing the report would be unfairly prejudicial after smith abandoned the case following trump s 2024 election victory lineberger worked in the same judicial district where smith s case against trump was filed that case accused trump of illegally retaining at the mar a lago property dozens of classified records from his first term and obstructing government efforts to get them back this fbi will not hesitate to bring to account those who violated the trust of the american public in an investigation that should ve never been brought to begin with fbi director kash patel said in a statement posted on x

<https://www.npr.org/2026/05/21/g-s1-123290/ex-prosecutor-charged-on-trump-classified-probe>

Netanyahu scolds Israeli security minister for videos taunting flotilla activists

Israel's minister of national security Itamar Ben-Gvir in the Israeli parliament during a session considering a bill to dissolve the government in Jerusalem Wednesday May 20 2026. Ohad Zwigenberg / AP Photo. Caption: Jerusalem: Israel's national security minister drew a sharp rebuke from Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and triggered a backlash abroad Wednesday after releasing videos taunting detained flotilla activists who tried to breach Israel's blockade of Gaza, telling them they should be imprisoned for a long time. Netanyahu said that although Israel has every right to stop provocative flotillas of Hamas terrorist supporters, the way national security minister Itamar Ben-Gvir dealt with the activists was not in line with Israel's values and norms. Ben-Gvir released videos Wednesday showing him walking among some of the approximately 430 detainees in one activists with their hands tied behind their backs, are kneeling, their heads touching the floor inside what appears to be a makeshift detention area, and on the deck of a ship, "Welcome to Israel, we are the landlords," says Ben-Gvir, waving a large Israeli flag. One handcuffed activist shouts "Free Palestine" as Ben-Gvir walks by and is immediately pushed to the ground by security personnel. In another video, Ben-Gvir says the activists came here all full of pride like big heroes, look at them now while appealing to Netanyahu to grant him permission to imprison them. "I say to Prime Minister Netanyahu, give them to me for a long, long time. Give them to us for the terrorist prisons," Ben-Gvir said. Netanyahu said he's given instructions that the activists be deported as soon as possible. Ben-Gvir drew the ire of Israeli Foreign Minister Gideon Saar, who publicly chastised his fellow minister on X, saying you knowingly caused harm to our state in this disgraceful display, no, you are not the face of Israel. Saar wrote Ben-Gvir shot back at Saar in the Israeli parliament, accusing him of bowing to the terrorists and that any Israeli apology to the activists would send a message of weakness, submission and surrender. An Israel-based legal advocacy group, the Legal Center for Arab Minority Rights in Israel, or Adalah, accused Israeli authorities of employing a criminal policy of abuse and humiliation against activists. Adalah's statement said this followed similar patterns of ill treatment by Israeli authorities against activists in previous flotilla missions for which Israel faced zero accountability. Adalah lawyer Suhad Bishara told the Associated Press a group of 11 lawyers who visited the detainees is aware of at least two activists who were hospitalized after being shot with rubber bullets for no reason without any justification. Bishara said the activists will be brought before a judge Thursday who will decide on when their deportation will begin. Flotilla spokesperson Rania Batrice said Ben-Gvir posts such videos because the world hasn't held Israel to account if they're doing that to Europeans and Americans and people from South Africa and all over the world. Imagine what they're doing to the Palestinian people. Batrice told the AP in an online interview. Batrice urged governments to step up their response. Strongly worded letters are not what we need right now. We need more action. British Foreign Secretary Yvette Cooper said the video violates the most basic standards of respect and dignity in how people should be treated and demanded an explanation from Israeli authorities. Italy condemned the detained activists' treatment as a violation of human dignity and called Ben-Gvir's videos unacceptable. It also summoned Israel's ambassador in Rome to protest the treatment of Italian detainees and demand their immediate release. Canadian Foreign Affairs Minister Anita Anand said she's directed her officials to summon the Israeli ambassador to Ottawa. Both Turkey and Greece condemned Israel's treatment of the activists. The Turkish Foreign Ministry said the behavior openly demonstrated to the world the violent and barbaric mindset of Israel's government. The Greek Foreign Ministry called Ben-Gvir's actions unacceptable and entirely condemnable and said it had lodged a formal protest. Palestinian militant group Hamas called out Ben-Gvir for the scenes of abuse and humiliation of the activists, saying they show Israel's moral decadence and sadism. Israeli forces on Tuesday boarded the last of the flotilla boats that tried to challenge the blockade, the latest effort to highlight the grim conditions for nearly 2 million Palestinians in Gaza. Flotilla organizers claimed Israeli soldiers fired on five boats during the interdictions, causing some damage. Israel's Foreign Ministry said no live ammunition was fired and that nonlethal means were aimed at the vessels as a warning but without targeting or injuring protesters. Israeli forces had begun stopping the flotilla, which had departed last week from Turkey around 268 kilometers (167 miles) from the Gaza coastline, according to the flotilla's website. Israel has called the flotilla a PR stunt at the service of Hamas with no real intent to deliver aid to Gaza. The boats carry a symbolic amount of aid. On Monday, the Israeli navy stopped 41 boats from the flotilla in international waters off Cyprus and detained those on

board more than a dozen irish nationals were aboard the flotilla including irish president catherine connolly's sister irish prime minister micheál martin has called israel's interception of the boats in international waters absolutely unacceptable the u.s. treasury however imposed sanctions against several european activists aboard the flotilla which u.s. treasury secretary scott bessent called pro terror israel has maintained a sea blockade of gaza since hamas took control of the territory in 2007 israeli authorities intensified it after the hamas led militant attacks on southern israel that killed around 1,200 people and saw more than 250 taken hostage on oct 7, 2023 critics say the blockade amounts to collective punishment israel says it's intended to prevent hamas from arming itself egypt which has the only border crossing with gaza not controlled by israel has also greatly restricted movement in and out israel's retaliatory offensive following the oct 7 attacks that started the war has killed more than 72,700 people according to gaza's health ministry the ministry part of gaza's hamas-run government doesn't give a breakdown between civilians and combatants it is staffed by medical professionals who maintain and publish detailed records viewed as generally reliable by the international community

<https://www.npr.org/2026/05/21/nx-s1-5829616/israeli-security-minister-flotilla>

Ebola fears surge on the ground in Congo over rapid spread of a rare type

family members of people who died of ebola stand next to coffins at a health center in rwampara congo wednesday may 20 2026 moses sawasawa aphide caption bunia congo anxious healthcare workers in eastern congo said wednesday they are underprotected and undertrained in a rapidly spreading ebola outbreak of a rare type of the virus in one of the world s most remote and vulnerable places long the scene of attacks by an array of armed groups the region s volatility now further complicates efforts to handle the crisis local leaders said an attack by militants linked to the islamic state group killed at least 17 people on tuesday night in alima village in ituri a province that has become the hot spot of the outbreak the world health organization which noted a low risk globally has said patient zero has not been found it s truly sad and painful because we ve already been through a security crisis and now ebola is here too said justin ndasi a bunia resident tons of health supplies have been airlifted to bunia where the first known death was announced last week but residents said masks are harder to find and some disinfectants that previously sold for 2 500 congolese francs about 1 now cost four times more at a treatment center in rwampara families cried and watched as healthcare workers in protective gear silently disinfected the bodies of their loved ones suspected ebola victims and placed them into coffins for secure burial sites the disease struck suddenly they said describing a rapid deterioration after symptoms were mistaken for illnesses such as malaria he told me his heart was hurting said botwine swanze who lost her son then he started crying because of the pain then he started bleeding and vomiting a lot the ebola virus is highly contagious and spreads in the human population through contact with bodily fluids such as vomit blood or semen symptoms include fever vomiting diarrhea muscle pain and at times internal and external bleeding who has declared the outbreak a public health emergency of international concern worried over its scale and speed the who chief in congo says it could last at least two months the rare type of ebola known as the bundibugyo virus spread undetected for weeks following the first known death while authorities tested for another more common ebola virus and came up negative investigations continued into where and when the outbreak started but given the scale we are thinking that it has started probably a couple of months ago said anaïs legand with who s emergencies program so far 51 cases have been confirmed in congo s northern provinces of ituri and north kivu and two cases in uganda who director general tedros adhanom ghebreyesus said wednesday there are 139 suspected deaths and almost 600 suspected cases but the scale of the epidemic is much larger he said the london based mrc centre for global infectious disease analysis estimated that cases have been substantially undercounted and that the actual number could already exceed 1 000 the true magnitude remains uncertain it said map showing suspected ebola cases as of may 18 2026 will jarrett ap photohide caption this is congo s 17th ebola outbreak and the who has said the country s health ministry has experienced staff and capacity to respond most outbreaks however were of the more common ebola type dr vasee moorthy a special adviser at who said a vaccine to address bundibugyo would not be available for at least six to nine months eastern congo already faced immense pressure from conflict displacement and a collapsing health system said dr lievin bangali senior health coordinator for the international rescue committee in congo adding that years of underfunding have weakened the response the outbreak highlights the effects of the trump administration s deep cuts in foreign aid u s secretary of state marco rubio has said the administration set a priority on funding 50 emergency clinics in affected areas the u s pledged to contribute 23 million in bunia schools and churches remain open while some residents wear masks elsewhere in ituri province suspected ebola patients share a ward with others injured or ill at bambu general hospital a doctors without borders team identified suspected cases over the weekend at bunia s salama hospital but found no available isolation ward in the area said trish newport an emergency program manager every health facility they called said we re full of suspect cases we don t have any space this gives you a vision of how crazy it is right now she said on social media in mongbwalu where the body of the first known death was taken the nearby border with uganda remains open and gold mining continues said chérubin kuku ndilawa a civil society leader there s no panic people continue with their normal lives but they re also starting to spread the word said ndilawa and noted a lack of public handwashing stations there were around 30 ebola patients at mongbwalu general hospital where a student from the local medical technology institute died on wednesday dr didier pay said the patients are scattered here and there said dr richard lokudu the

hospital's medical director we hope for the proper triage and isolation facilities to be installed today and if that doesn't happen we will be completely overwhelmed they are understaffed and not trained to handle suspected cases lokudu said and added that if confirmed cases surge we have no protection in the ebola affected city of goma where rwanda backed m23 rebels are in control the situation is complicated said dr anne ancia who's representative in congo a u.s. national who tested positive in congo arrived in berlin on wednesday and was in a special isolation ward where a comprehensive examination was underway german health ministry spokesperson martin elsässer said elsässer declined to comment on the condition of the patient who has not been identified by german or u.s. authorities the ministry later said without elaborating that it would take in the patient's wife and three children at the request of u.s. authorities a top health official in the czech republic said they are receiving an american doctor who was treating ebola patients in uganda and who is without symptoms it was not clear whether any were infected dr satish pillai incident manager for centers for disease control and prevention's ebola response told reporters wednesday that the americans were being transported in coordination with the u.s. state department and other agencies one patient who is in stable condition is now being treated in germany pillai said asked whether the white house played a role in the decision to move the americans to europe pillai said the decision was based on conditions on the ground and the need to mobilize rapidly

<https://www.npr.org/2026/05/21/nx-s1-5829610/ebola-fears-surge>

Liberal U.S. mayors team up with European counterparts to fight authoritarianism

Lacey Beaty, mayor of Beaverton, Ore., represented one of the U.S. cities that recently joined the Pact of Free Cities for its recent meeting in Bratislava, Slovakia. In the background from left to right are Omar Al Rawi, member of the Vienna City Council; Audrey Pulvar, deputy mayor of Paris; Gergely Karácsony, mayor of Budapest; and Rafał Trzaskowski, mayor of Warsaw. Courtesy of the City of Bratislava.

Right-wing populists in the U.S. have been building political ties across the Atlantic Ocean for years to support and learn from one another. Think President Trump, who developed a close relationship with former Hungarian Prime Minister Viktor Orbán. Now 10 U.S. mayors from liberal cities are following suit, joining a group called the Pact of Free Cities, where they can share strategies with their European counterparts on how to defend democracy and fight authoritarianism.

The American cities, including Boston, Chicago, San Antonio, and Cincinnati, joined the pact virtually or in person last week for its annual meeting in Bratislava, Slovakia. I've joined the pact of free cities because of the actions of the Trump administration that continue to not just have democratic institutions and democratic values backslide in our country but also the destruction of long-standing relationships all over the world but particularly with our European counterparts.

Said Cincinnati Mayor Aftab Pureval, the mayors of Bratislava, Budapest, Prague, and Warsaw founded the group in 2019 to stand up for progressive values and brainstorm on how to deal with what they see as hostile national governments.

Budapest Mayor Gergely Karácsony told fellow mayors at the pact of free cities meeting how Hungarian voters swept the nation's autocratic leader, former Prime Minister Viktor Orbán, from power after 16 years. Courtesy of the City of Bratislava.

Courtesy of the City of Bratislava. Hide caption: At last week's meeting, Gergely Karácsony, the mayor of Budapest, shared lessons from the recent defeat of Orbán, who many political analysts say developed an authoritarian playbook that has informed some of Trump's efforts to undermine the U.S. system of checks and balances.

Karácsony said one of the turning points came last year when the Hungarian government tried to ban the annual Pride parade in Budapest. This was meant partly to intimidate people and partly to provoke a debate that would divert political discussion away from economic problems toward symbolic issues.

Karácsony said instead of engaging with Orbán's government over LGBTQ rights, Karácsony said the city took over the parade and made it about something bigger: the right to free speech and free assembly. Tens of thousands of people defied the Hungarian government and marched across the city, Karácsony said. The defiance exposed Orbán's political weakness and contributed to his defeat last month, ending 16 years in office.

Gergely Karácsony, mayor of Budapest, foreground, and Matus Vallo, mayor of Bratislava, center, at the sixth meeting of the pact of free cities, a group of more than forty municipalities working together to defend democracy and fight authoritarianism. Hide caption: Lacey Beaty, the progressive mayor of Beaverton, Ore., flew across nine time zones for last week's meeting. Upon returning home, she told NPR the trip was worth it. It was unexpectedly collaborative and just really underlined that a lot of the issues we're facing here in the United States, other cities are facing too, she said.

Beaty said those challenges include funding cuts by federal governments that don't like cities' liberal politics. For instance, she said the Trump administration tried to cut a chunk of funding to Beaverton because it refused to dump its DEI policy.

Karácsony said Orbán's government put similar pressure on Budapest, threatening city services such as garbage pickup. The mayor responded by putting big signs on the sides of trash trucks that pointed the finger at Orbán and his Fidesz party, who would not want this bin to be emptied tomorrow. The signs read: Beaty said this illustrates why mayors need precise messaging to tell residents when the federal government cuts funding in part so local officials don't get blamed.

NPR reached out to the White House for comment on the U.S. mayors joining the pact of free cities. White House spokeswoman Abigail Jackson responded with the following statement: If Democrat mayors spent half as much time prioritizing the safety and security of their own citizens instead of participating in Trump's derangement syndrome publicity stunts, their residents would be much better served.

Building ties with like-minded politicians in other countries isn't new. The conservative Political Action Conference (CPAC) has been cultivating relationships with right-wing populists in Europe for a decade. The pact of free cities held its annual meeting in the Hall of Mirrors in the Primate's Palace in Bratislava, Slovakia. The mayors traded strategies for countering right-wing populist national governments in their home countries.

Courtesy of the City of Bratislava. Hide caption: CPAC chairman Matt Schlapp said those relationships have been

informative and cites nigel Farage leader of reform UK a right wing party that beat the ruling labor party in local elections earlier this month. Schlapp said Farage who was a major force behind the 2016 Brexit vote showed how to mainstream blunt talk about immigration that many on Britain's political left found offensive and xenophobic in talking to Nigel. I realized that it was on a parallel path to the conversation of immigration in America where the Democrats and the Republicans had made any scrutiny of immigration essentially to be racist, said Schlapp. CPAC also built ties with Orbán holding five annual meetings in Budapest regarding the Pact of Free Cities. Schlapp questioned whether European mayors would learn much from their American counterparts given some of the particular problems facing U.S. cities including violent crime and extensive homelessness but he added that if U.S. mayors can use lessons from Europe to develop grassroots support back here that could prove useful. My private advice is they're probably doing the right thing to try to organize, Schlapp said.

<https://www.npr.org/2026/05/21/nx-s1-5827032/liberal-u-s-mayor-trump-europe-pact-of-free-cities-democracy-authoritarianism-orban>

Senate panel hears testimony on online sports betting prediction markets

A Senate subcommittee lawmakers on Wednesday questioned sports betting industry officials during a hearing focused on recent cheating scandals, companies' marketing tactics, and regulatory battles. U.S. lawmakers grilled representatives of sportsbook and prediction market companies about their aggressive marketing tactics and the cheating allegations that have plagued sports leagues in recent months. As advocates for more stringent regulation drove home the pitfalls of legalized gambling, the Senate Commerce Subcommittee hearing on Wednesday comes as athletes from college basketball to the major leagues face accusations that they rigged games for financial gain. And as states try to put guardrails on prediction markets, Committee Chair Ted Cruz (R-Texas) raised two key questions before the panel: first, in a world where sports betting exists, how do we preserve the integrity and authenticity of the sports that we love? and second, are prediction markets operating within the law or are they defying the law and improperly infringing on state sovereignty? He said Cruz pointed to recent high-profile instances of alleged game tampering, including two MLB pitchers accused of taking bribes in exchange for adjusting their own throws. He also noted the cancellations of UFC fights due to suspicions of match fixing. These incidents sow doubt in the minds of fans, he said, that is why sports leagues and casinos and regulators have to work together to identify, investigate, and root out manipulation. Other lawmakers questioned the advertising techniques of prediction market companies such as the popular Kalshi and Polymarket platforms. The fast-growing platforms allow anyone 18 and older to legally bet on topics as benign as phrases a particular celebrity might make at an event to the more macabre such as predictions surrounding the assassination of Iran's Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. Sen. John Hickenlooper (D-Colo.) raised concerns that the companies' social media ads could reach young people who are particularly at risk of getting sucked into problem gambling. Patrick McHenry, a former Republican congressman and current senior adviser for the Coalition for Prediction Markets, told the committee that the sites ban bettors under 18 years old and that the average age of users is 33. Sportsbooks require bettors to be 21. Online sports betting has seen explosive growth in recent years, with 39 states and D.C. having legalized some form of mobile sports gambling after a 2018 Supreme Court decision opened the door for states to legalize online sports gambling. Sports betting revenue hit a record \$16.96 billion in 2025, according to the American Gaming Association, but the recent cheating scandals as well as concerns over gambling addiction have led to calls for additional scrutiny over the industry. Harry Levant, director of gambling policy at the Public Health Advocacy Institute, outlined those concerns to the Senate subcommittee. He pointed to his own history of problematic gambling as evidence of how the practice can spiral. For some, this is not a Republican issue or a Democrat issue; this is a human issue regarding an addiction crisis that needs to be addressed and prevented, he said. But Bill Miller, CEO of the American Gaming Association, argued that online gambling was already one of the most closely regulated American industries and called his sector an essential part of the U.S. economy. Minnesota this week became the first state to ban prediction markets from operating inside its borders, setting the stage for a heated legal battle with the Trump administration. More than a dozen other states have introduced bills attempting to crack down on the platforms. According to the National Conference of State Legislatures, prediction market companies argue that they should be overseen by the federal government and classified as a financial product known as a futures contract, not as gambling. Services the Trump administration has supported this view, suing states that have attempted to rein in the industry. In his remarks to the committee Wednesday, McHenry argued that attempts to regulate prediction markets like traditional gambling proves a fundamental misunderstanding of the industry. In a casino or sportsbook, the house sets the odds and profits when customers lose. In a prediction market, exchange participants trade with one another while the platform earns transaction fees for facilitating the market, McHenry said. As a result, the incentives are fundamentally different: prediction markets benefit from greater participation, liquidity, and more accurate information, not from consumers losing money.

<https://www.npr.org/2026/05/20/nx-s1-5829166/senate-panel-hears-testimony-on-online-sports-betting-prediction-markets>

Advice for 2026 commencement speakers: Don't bring up AI

real estate executive gloria caulfield left was the graduation speaker at university of central florida and big machine records ceo scott borchetta spoke at middle tennessee state university's graduation both speakers were booed by students when they brought up artificial intelligence university of central florida and middle tennessee state university via storyful screenshots by nprhide caption glendale community college's commencement ceremonies hit a snag just as students were walking across the stage to get their diplomas last week the wrong names were being read aloud at the ceremony just outside phoenix some of the graduates' names didn't even get read the college's president tiffany hernandez tried to explain the problem we're using a new AI system as our reader she said leading to loud boos from the audience in a statement the college blamed technical issues and said it had apologized to students for the experience other commencement speakers who have brought up the sweeping changes that artificial intelligence is driving are also facing boos from the class of 2026 real estate executive gloria caulfield described AI to the graduating class of the university of central florida on may 8 as the next industrial revolution credit university of central florida via storyful graduating students at middle tennessee state university booed when record executive scott borchetta told them at their may 9 commencement ceremony AI is rewriting production as we sit here borchetta responded to the boos with deal with it like I said it's a tool as the booing continued he added then do something about it it's a tool make it work for you credit middle tennessee state university via storyful former google CEO eric schmidt was repeatedly booed by university of arizona graduates at their commencement on may 15 including when he said the question is not whether AI will shape the world it will the question is whether you will help shape artificial intelligence chatGPT was released in 2022 when many of this year's undergraduates were just starting college many have embraced AI for good and for ill whether to build businesses or use it to cheat but despite or perhaps because of those experiences many graduates feel those boos are justified I think my gut reaction was I would be one of those people in the crowd booing said maggie simmons who will attend her own graduation ceremony at the university of denver next month she told NPR she is concerned AI is hurting the planet and harming black and minority communities AI language models have been found to reinforce systemic racism and data centers needed to power AI systems have had a disproportionate impact on minority neighborhoods the future should be these people in this room that are earning their degree and now going out into the workforce said simmons who studied molecular biology and spanish to prepare to become a pediatrician one day we should be celebrating them and their brains not some artificial intelligence that in the future is going to take their jobs and especially without regulation kareen gill a recent graduate of american university with a political science degree thinks a lot of her generation is feeling pessimistic about AI I think at the beginning we were excited about it and it was this cool thing oh I can write an essay for you but now like we don't want that anymore and we don't want it messing with our job prospects and messing with the jobs that we've worked for years so hard for four years to kind of be eligible for gill said one immediate impact gill said she has noticed is fewer internships and entry-level positions doing things like answering phones because AI is replacing some of those jobs so we're seeing that firsthand and we're seeing how much it's disadvantaging us said gill but I don't think that older generations are necessarily in our shoes in that way it's not really going to impact their future on the rest of their adulthood in the same way indeed a march poll from quinnipiac university showed that there are generational differences in how concerned americans are about AI taking jobs gen Z despite being more familiar with AI is the most pessimistic about jobs with 81 saying that AI will decrease job opportunities said chetan jaiswal an associate professor of computer science and associate chair of the department of computing at quinnipiac who also worked on the poll jaiswal said that the poll showed that americans overall are more concerned and less excited about AI as the technology's impacts are becoming more evident people are not rejecting AI but people are asking questions now since the initial AI fever is gone jaiswal said that point was echoed by gill the recent AU graduate who said her generation's concerns about AI go far beyond getting their first jobs how they're making billionaires richer and depleting our environment has really opened our eyes to the ripple effects of AI she said indeed quinnipiac's poll found only 5% of americans feel AI development is being led by people or organizations that represent their interests

<https://www.npr.org/2026/05/20/nx-s1-5822419/ai-colleges-commencement-booing>

Elon Musk's SpaceX IPO plans reveal blockbuster spending on rockets and AI

A SpaceX rocket is getting prepared for another attempt to liftoff at NASA's Kennedy Space Center in Cape Canaveral, FL on Sept 9, 2024. The Elon Musk controlled company is preparing to go public in what is expected to be the biggest listing in history. Joe Raedle/Getty Images North America. **Caption:** Elon Musk's SpaceX is getting ready to break new records on Wall Street and make one of the world's wealthiest men even wealthier. The space launch company filed financial information with regulators to pull off what could be the biggest initial public offering ever in mid-June, though it did not disclose how much it intends to raise. Previous media reports have said the company is seeking about \$80 billion, that would make it by far the largest IPO in history, much higher than the \$29 billion that Saudi Aramco eventually raised after its 2019 offering. The deal could also value the company at over \$1 trillion, making SpaceX one of the most valuable companies in the world and potentially even worth more than Musk's electric vehicle company Tesla. The IPO would also massively enrich Musk, who is already one of the world's wealthiest people and who could become its first trillionaire. The former adviser to President Trump controls 85% of voting power in the company. According to the documents filed on Wednesday, SpaceX's initial public offering has been expected for months. Earlier this year, the company filed confidential paperwork with the U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission to start the process of selling its shares to the public. The associated press and others reported in April the IPO could set off a blockbuster year for Wall Street, which is also anticipating potential listings from OpenAI and Anthropic, the makers of ChatGPT and Claude, respectively. Such IPOs will put a public value on and eventually allow ordinary investors to buy into some of the most powerful private tech companies driving the AI boom. SpaceX is among them. The company has already cornered the market on space launches, makes reusable rockets and has built the world's only satellite internet service, Starlink. Last year, it merged with Musk's artificial intelligence company, xAI. Going forward, Musk wants to build orbital data centers, moon bases and eventually put humans on the surface of Mars. The filing shows SpaceX is spending eye-watering amounts of money to fulfill those ambitions. Last year, xAI more than doubled capital spending to \$12.7 billion, driven by data center development and construction. The company spent another \$3 billion last year developing its massive new rocket, Starship. In the first quarter of this year, two of SpaceX's three main businesses lost money. Its rocket launching business reported an operating loss of \$662 million, while its AI business lost nearly \$2.5 billion. Only its satellite communications business, which runs Starlink, turned a operating profit of \$1.2 billion. Overall, the company reported a net loss of nearly \$4.3 billion between January and March on total revenue of \$4.7 billion. IPOs allow public markets investors, including individual investors, to buy shares in some of the buzziest and high-profile companies. The deals also raise tremendous amounts of money for the companies that are selling these shares and the private investors who have funded their pre-IPO growth. Analysts are also hoping that the SpaceX IPO will kickstart what has been a relatively slow market for initial public offerings in the past several years, but there are some risks for individual investors looking to buy into SpaceX as it goes public. Post-IPO companies tend to see their share prices underperform the broader market. Historically speaking, it's pretty jarring how bad it is, says Franco Granda, a research analyst who covers SpaceX for the data firm Pitchbook. He adds that for closely watched companies like SpaceX, which saw its valuation soar under private ownership, going public also means being much more open to scrutiny from financial regulators and the general public. Now they're under much heavier scrutiny and the big valuation sometimes is hard to justify, he says. Then President-elect Donald Trump and Elon Musk watch the launch of the sixth test flight of the SpaceX Starship rocket on Nov. 19, 2024, in Brownsville, Texas. Brandon Bell/Getty Images North America. **Caption:** Perhaps no company is more closely tied to Elon Musk than SpaceX. Musk founded the company in 2002 with the goal of one day creating a self-sustaining colony on Mars. He single-handedly revolutionized the rocket industry by creating a reusable first stage that saved huge amounts of money. SpaceX has gone on to win numerous contracts launching defense satellites, commercial payloads and even astronauts on board its Dragon capsule. It's secured billions in contracts from the Department of Defense and NASA. According to an analysis by the independent firm Brycetek, 85% of all launches last year were aboard SpaceX rockets, putting the private company ahead of even nation-states like China and Russia. Despite this dominance, launching things into space actually accounts for only a small part of SpaceX's revenue, said Tim Farrar, president of TMF Associates. By far, the larger

part of the company's revenue comes from Starlink. The company generated 11.4bn in revenue from its connectivity division in 2025 compared with 4.1bn from its space launch division and 3.2bn from its AI business, the filings show. But Farrar thinks even Starlink can't entirely justify a trillion-dollar valuation. The valuation is completely dependent on the degree to which people believe in Elon Musk, he said. It's not dependent on the current business.

<https://www.npr.org/2026/05/20/nx-s1-5812731/elon-musk-spacex-ai-ipo>

Supreme Court voting rights ruling could play a big role at the local level

the supreme court's recent ruling threatens the power of racial minority voters in voting rights act cases about not just congress but also at least 17 state and local governments npr finds read more why the supreme court's voting rights ruling could play a big role at the local level juana summers host the supreme court's recent decision to undermine the voting rights act is sending shockwaves across the country that ruling struck down a louisiana congressional map as an unconstitutional racial gerrymander but the impact goes well beyond maps for congress npr's hanshi lo wang reports hanshi lo wang byline npr has found active legal fights over at least 17 voting maps or election systems for state legislatures county commissions school boards or other local governments all of them are now reckoning with the supreme court's weakening of the voting rights act specifically its section 2 protections against discrimination of minority voters in places where voting is racially polarized michael li what section 2 did is it helped break down political fiefdoms that existed in the south wang michael li is a redistricting expert at the brennan center for justice a think tank that advocates for expanding voting access li and the real danger now is you're going to see the white majority in these places reassert its primacy and really design maps to lock it in wang most of the active section 2 cases were brought by black voters in the south but not all native american voters are in a legal fight over north dakota's legislative map and latino voters are challenging how members of a local pennsylvania school board are elected gilda daniels a law professor at the university of baltimore says the supreme court's ruling has encouraged opponents of local majority minority districts to come up with new ways of getting rid of them gilda daniels it's very important for folks to be vigilant and to participate on the local levels ensuring that they're aware of what's happening cause there are some jurisdictions that could decide you know we're going to move from districts to at large wang at large voting systems where no voting districts are involved have been challenged with many voting rights lawsuits over the decades says maureen edobor an assistant law professor at washington and lee university maureen edobor at large districts can effectively render minority votes wasted they won't count because you'll never clear the threshold of a majority required to elect the candidate of your choice wang in tennessee's fayette county elton holmes president of the local naacp branch is bracing for more setbacks for black voters after the supreme court's latest weakening of the voting rights act elton holmes i'll just put it like this i don't think the majority of the citizens of the united states realized what had just happened wang last year holmes naacp branch led a section 2 lawsuit over the voting map for fayette county's board of commissioners its members are all white eventually the county agreed to a new map where 3 out of 10 voting districts are majority black the county recently held its first primary election under the new districts holmes right now the way i see it if 2026 election doesn't go too well they will come back and put those gerrymandering maps back into play wang get rid of those three majority black districts holmes yeah they will eliminate the three minority majority districts yeah wang fayette county's mayor rhea skip taylor tells npr he does not see any plans for doing any additional redistricting in the county before the 2030 census but with a mid decade gerrymandering fight for congress still playing out in some parts of the country holmes says he doesn't rule out more gerrymandering at the local level holmes it's just been a struggle and then we finally get a little breakthrough and then something else pop up to try to push it back some more wang other voting rights advocates are also watching for changes to state and local voting maps the advocacy groups fair fight action and black voters matter fund estimate the supreme court's ruling has put at risk close to 200 democratic held state legislative seats mostly representing majority black districts in the south hanshi lo wang npr news soundbite of music copyright 2026 npr all rights reserved visit our website terms of use and permissions pages at www.npr.org for further information accuracy and availability of npr transcripts may vary transcript text may be revised to correct errors or match updates to audio audio on npr.org may be edited after its original broadcast or publication the authoritative record of npr's programming is the audio record juana summers host the supreme court's recent decision to undermine the voting rights act is sending shockwaves across the country that ruling struck down a louisiana congressional map as an unconstitutional racial gerrymander but the impact goes well beyond maps for congress npr's hanshi lo wang reports 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All rights reserved. Visit our website terms of use and permissions pages at www.npr.org for further information. Accuracy and availability of NPR transcripts may vary. Transcript text may be revised to correct errors or match updates to audio. Audio on npr.org may be edited after its original broadcast or publication. The authoritative record of NPR's programming is the audio record. The Supreme Court's recent decision to undermine the Voting Rights Act is sending shockwaves across the country that ruling struck down a Louisiana congressional map as an unconstitutional racial gerrymander but the impact goes well beyond maps for Congress. NPR's Hansi Lo Wang reports. Hansi Lo Wang byline. NPR has found active legal fights over at least 17 voting maps or election systems for state legislatures county commissions school boards or other local governments all of them are now reckoning with the Supreme Court's weakening of the Voting Rights Act specifically its Section 2 protections against discrimination of minority voters in places where voting is racially polarized. Michael Li what Section 2 did is it helped break down political fiefdoms that existed in the South. Wang Michael Li is a redistricting expert at the Brennan Center for Justice a think tank that advocates for expanding voting access. Li and the real danger now is you're going to see the white majority in these places reassert its primacy and really design maps to lock it in. Wang most of the active Section 2 cases were brought by black voters in the South but not all Native American voters are in a legal fight over North Dakota's legislative map and Latino voters are challenging how members of a local Pennsylvania school board are elected. Gilda Daniels a law professor at the University of Baltimore says the Supreme Court's ruling has encouraged opponents of local majority minority districts to come up with new ways of getting rid of them. Gilda Daniels it's very important for folks to be vigilant and to participate on the local levels ensuring that they're aware of what's happening cause there are some jurisdictions that could decide you know we're going to move from districts to at large voting systems where no voting districts are involved have been challenged with many voting rights lawsuits over the decades says Maureen Edobor an assistant law professor at Washington and Lee University. Maureen Edobor at large districts can effectively render minority votes wasted they won't count because you'll never clear the threshold of a majority required to elect the candidate of your choice. Wang in Tennessee's Fayette County Elton Holmes president of the local NAACP branch is bracing for more setbacks for black voters after the Supreme Court's latest weakening of the Voting Rights Act. Elton Holmes I'll just put it like this I don't think the majority of the citizens of the United States realized what had just happened. Wang last year Holmes NAACP branch led a Section 2 lawsuit over the voting map for Fayette County's board of commissioners its members are all white eventually the county agreed to a new map where 3 out of 10 voting districts are majority black the county recently held its first primary election under the new districts Holmes right now the way I see it if 2026 election doesn't go too well they will come back and put those

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audio on npr.org may be edited after its original broadcast or publication. the authoritative record of npr's programming is the audio record. michael li: what section 2 did is it helped break down political fiefdoms that existed in the south. wang: michael li is a redistricting expert at the brennan center for justice, a think tank that advocates for expanding voting access. li: and the real danger now is you're going to see the white majority in these places reassert its primacy and really design maps to lock it in. wang: most of the active section 2 cases were brought by black voters in the south, but not all native american voters are in a legal fight over north dakota's legislative map, and latino voters are challenging how members of a local pennsylvania school board are elected. gilda daniels, a law professor at the university of baltimore, says the supreme court's ruling has encouraged opponents of local majority-minority districts to come up with new ways of getting rid of them. gilda daniels: it's very important for folks to be vigilant and to participate on the local levels, ensuring that they're aware of what's happening, because there are some jurisdictions that could decide you know we're going to move from districts to at-large. wang: at large voting systems where no voting districts are involved have been challenged with many voting rights lawsuits over the decades, says maureen edobor, an assistant law professor at washington and lee university. maureen edobor: at large districts can effectively render minority votes wasted. they won't count because you'll never clear the threshold of a majority required to elect the candidate of your choice. wang: in tennessee's fayette county, elton holmes, president of the local naacp branch, is bracing for more setbacks for black voters after the supreme court's latest weakening of the voting rights act. elton holmes: i'll just put it like this: i don't think the majority of the citizens of the united states realized what had just happened. wang: last year holmes naacp branch led a section 2 lawsuit over the voting map for fayette county's board of commissioners. its members are all white. eventually the county agreed to a new map where 3 out of 10 voting districts are majority black. the county recently held its first primary election under the new districts. holmes: right now the way i see it, if 2026 election doesn't go too well, they will come back and put those gerrymandering maps back into play. wang: get rid of those three majority black districts. holmes: yeah, they will eliminate the three minority majority districts. yeah, wang. fayette county's mayor rhea skip taylor tells npr he does not see any plans for doing any additional redistricting in the county before the 2030 census, but with a mid-decade gerrymandering fight for congress still playing out in some parts of the country, holmes says he doesn't rule out more gerrymandering at the local level. holmes: it's just been a struggle, and then we finally get a little breakthrough, and then something else pops up to try to push it back. some more. wang: other voting rights advocates are also watching for changes to state and local voting maps. the advocacy groups fair fight action and black voters matter fund estimate the supreme court's ruling has put at risk close to 200 democratic-held state legislative seats, mostly representing majority black districts in the south. hanshi lo wang: npr news soundbite of music. copyright 2026 npr. all rights reserved. visit our website: [terms-of-use](https://www.npr.org/terms-of-use) and [permissions](https://www.npr.org/permissions) pages at www.npr.org for further information. accuracy and availability of npr transcripts may vary. transcript text may be revised to correct errors or match updates to audio.

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updates to audio audio on npr.org may be edited after its original broadcast or publication the authoritative record of npr's programming is the audio record wang at large voting systems where no voting districts are involved have been challenged with many voting rights lawsuits over the decades says maureen edobor an assistant law professor at washington and lee university maureen edobor at large districts can effectively render minority votes wasted they won't count because you'll never clear the threshold of a majority required to elect the candidate of your choice wang in tennessee's fayette county elton holmes president of the local naacp branch is bracing for more setbacks for black voters after the supreme court's latest weakening of the voting rights act elton holmes i'll just put it like this i don't think the majority of the citizens of the united states realized what had just happened wang last year holmes naacp branch led a section 2 lawsuit over the voting map for fayette 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commissioners its members are all white eventually the county agreed to a new map where 3 out of 10 voting districts are majority black the county recently held its first primary election under the new districts holmes right now the way i see it if 2026 election doesn't go too well they will come back and put those gerrymandering maps back into play wang get rid of those three majority black districts holmes yeah they will eliminate the three minority majority districts yeah wang fayette county's mayor rhea skip taylor tells npr he does not see any plans for doing any additional redistricting in the county before the 2030 census but with a mid decade gerrymandering fight for congress still playing out in some parts of the country holmes says he doesn't rule out more gerrymandering at the local level holmes it's just been a struggle and then we finally get a little breakthrough and then something else pop up to try to push it back some more wang other voting rights advocates are also watching for changes to state and local voting maps the advocacy groups fair fight action and black voters matter fund estimate the supreme court's ruling has put at risk close to 200 democratic held state legislative seats mostly representing majority black districts in the south hansi lo wang npr news soundbite of music copyright 2026 npr all rights reserved visit our website terms of use and permissions pages at www.npr.org for further information accuracy and availability of npr transcripts may vary transcript text may be revised to correct errors or match updates to audio audio on npr.org may be edited after its original broadcast or publication the authoritative record of npr's programming is the audio record wang last year holmes naacp branch led a section 2 lawsuit over the voting map for fayette county's board of commissioners its members are all white eventually the county agreed to a new map where 3 out of 10 voting districts are majority black the county recently held its first primary election under the new districts holmes right now the way i see it if 2026 election doesn't go too well they will come back and put those gerrymandering maps back into play wang get rid of those three majority black districts holmes yeah they will eliminate the three minority majority districts yeah wang fayette county's mayor rhea skip taylor tells npr he does not see any plans for doing any additional redistricting in the county before the 2030 census but with a mid decade gerrymandering fight for congress still playing out in some parts of the country holmes says he doesn't rule out more gerrymandering at the local level holmes it's just been a struggle and then we finally get a little breakthrough and then something else pop up to try to push it back some more wang other voting rights advocates are also watching for changes to state and local voting maps the advocacy groups fair fight action and black voters matter fund estimate the supreme court's ruling has put at risk close to 200 democratic held state legislative seats mostly representing majority black districts in the south hansi lo wang npr news soundbite of music copyright 2026 npr all rights reserved visit our website terms of use and permissions pages at www.npr.org for further information accuracy and availability of npr transcripts may vary transcript text may be revised to correct errors or match updates to audio audio on npr.org may be edited after its original broadcast or publication the authoritative record of npr's programming is the audio record holmes right now the way i see it if 2026 election doesn't go too well they will come back and put those gerrymandering maps back into play wang get rid of those three majority black districts holmes yeah they will eliminate the three minority majority districts yeah wang fayette county's mayor rhea skip taylor tells npr he does not see any plans for doing any additional redistricting in the county before the 2030 census but with a mid decade gerrymandering fight for congress still playing out in

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